Module 08: Planning — The Body's Anticipatory Wisdom

Learning Objectives

1. Explain how **embodied planning** draws on the felt sense to evaluate future scenarios through somatic simulation rather than purely abstract calculation.
2. Describe the concept of **allostatic anticipation** — the body's proactive preparation for expected future demands — as a form of interoceptive planning.
3. Analyze the role of **expected free energy** in guiding the felt sense of which futures feel viable, desirable, or threatening.
4. Recognize the integration of somatic and cognitive planning as the culmination of the felt sense module sequence.

Introduction

You are considering a major life decision — a move to a new city, a career change, an ending of a relationship. You have made lists of pros and cons, consulted friends, analyzed the practical details. But what finally tips the decision is something else: when you imagine living in the new city, your chest opens and your breathing deepens. When you imagine staying, your shoulders hunch and your stomach tightens. The body has planned its future before the mind has finished deliberating.

Planning, in the felt sense framework, is not a purely cognitive operation performed in the prefrontal cortex. It is an embodied process in which the body simulates future states and evaluates them through interoceptive prediction. The felt sense of a future — its felt viability, its felt rightness — provides information that no amount of abstract reasoning can replicate. Active inference formalizes this: planning is the evaluation of possible action policies based on their **expected free energy** — the predicted surprise, uncertainty, and distance from preferred states that each policy would produce. The body's felt response to an imagined future is the phenomenology of this evaluation.

Key Concepts

1. Somatic Simulation of Future States

When you imagine a future scenario, your body does not merely think about it — it partially enacts it. Imagining a stressful meeting produces a measurable stress response: elevated cortisol, increased heart rate, muscular tension. Imagining a peaceful scene produces relaxation: slower breathing, reduced blood pressure, muscular release. These somatic simulations are the body's way of previewing the interoceptive consequences of future states. In active inference, this preview is the evaluation of expected free energy: the generative model runs forward in time, predicting the interoceptive states that each possible future would produce, and the felt sense registers the result.

2. Allostatic Anticipation

The body does not merely react to current conditions — it **anticipates** future demands and adjusts its internal states proactively. Before a marathon, the body increases glycogen stores. Before a stressful exam, cortisol rises. Before an anticipated social encounter, the autonomic nervous system shifts toward the appropriate state of arousal. This allostatic anticipation is planning at the most basic, visceral level: the generative model predicts future interoceptive demands and adjusts current physiology to minimize the expected free energy of the upcoming state transition.

3. The Felt Sense of Temporal Horizon

Different plans have different temporal horizons, and the felt sense registers this difference somatically. An immediate plan (reaching for a glass) produces a crisp, localized somatic anticipation — the proprioceptive readiness of the reaching arm. A medium-term plan (preparing for a presentation next week) produces a more diffuse, ongoing somatic tone — a background state of engagement tinged with apprehension. A long-term plan (imagining retirement) produces a vague, atmospheric felt quality — a bodily mood that colors the present without specifying any particular action. In active inference, these differences correspond to the depth of temporal inference in the generative model's hierarchical structure.

4. Intuitive Planning and the Wisdom of the Body

Gendlin and others in the Focusing tradition emphasize that the body often knows the right direction before the mind catches up. The felt sense of a good plan — the opening, the forward-leaning energy, the sense of "yes" — and the felt sense of a bad plan — the constriction, the pulling back, the sense of "not quite" — provide a rapid, holistic evaluation that integrates more information than conscious deliberation can hold. In active inference, this intuitive planning reflects the generative model's capacity to evaluate expected free energy across many dimensions simultaneously, compressing the result into a single interoceptive signal.

5. Planning Across Time: The Integration of Past, Present, and Future

Embodied planning is not only forward-looking. It integrates **past experience** (somatic memory of how similar situations unfolded), **present state** (the body's current interoceptive condition), and **anticipated future** (the simulated interoceptive consequences of planned actions). This temporal integration occurs within the generative model's hierarchical structure, where priors from past learning constrain predictions about the future, and the present felt sense provides the evaluative anchor. Planning, in this framework, is the body's way of weaving a coherent temporal narrative through the fabric of its own sensation.

Active Inference Connection

In active inference, planning is formalized as the selection of action policies that minimize **expected free energy** — a quantity that balances the drive to reduce uncertainty (epistemic value) with the drive to fulfill preferences (pragmatic value). The felt sense is the phenomenological expression of this evaluation: the body's somatic response to a planned future is its report on the expected free energy of that future. Plans that minimize expected free energy feel right — viable, attractive, energizing. Plans that increase expected free energy feel wrong — threatening, depleting, aversive. The body is not merely executing plans devised by the mind; it is actively participating in their evaluation and selection.

Experiential Applications

- **Practice — Felt Sense Decision-Making**: When facing a choice between two options, close your eyes and vividly imagine living with Option A for the next year. Attend to the felt sense that arises in your body — its quality, location, and energy. Then do the same with Option B. The somatic difference between the two simulations contains information that your lists of pros and cons cannot capture. You are comparing the expected free energy of two possible futures through your body's own evaluative system.

- **Case Study — Pre-Competition Somatic Preparation in Athletes**: Elite athletes report extensive pre-performance planning that is more somatic than cognitive. A diver visualizes and physically feels each twist and rotation before stepping onto the board. A basketball player's pre-shot routine engages the felt sense of the arc, the release, the follow-through. This somatic rehearsal is not mere visualization — it is active inference in the planning register, the generative model running forward simulations that calibrate proprioceptive predictions and motor precision before the action itself begins.

Cross-References

- **Module 07 (Communication)**: Communicating plans requires translating felt sense evaluations into shareable language.
- **Module 01 (Systems)**: The body's systemic integrity constrains and enables all planning — you can only plan what your body can sustain.
- **Unit 03 (Intuitive Knowing)**: Intuitive planning draws on the tacit expertise that accumulated felt sense provides.

Summary

Planning in the felt sense framework is the body's anticipatory wisdom — its capacity to simulate future states, evaluate them somatically, and guide action selection through the felt quality of imagined outcomes. Allostatic anticipation, somatic simulation, and the intuitive evaluation of temporal horizons all contribute to an embodied planning process that integrates more information, across more dimensions, than conscious deliberation alone can manage.

Active inference reveals planning as expected free energy minimization: the body evaluating possible futures by predicting their interoceptive consequences and selecting the paths that feel most viable. This module completes the felt sense sequence, showing how interoceptive intelligence — from systems through agents, perception, cognition, action, learning, and communication — culminates in the body's capacity to orient toward the future it most wants to inhabit.